

Lakes

Lakes are big pools of water that form in natural hollows. Some are basins of impermeable rock that are fed by streams, while others are filled by water seeping up from below. They may be rich in life or almost barren. The more plant nutrients a lake contains, the more quickly it becomes overgrown and turns into a marsh or swamp.

FLOODED BASINS

Many lakes are scooped out of hard, impermeable rock by the moving ice of glaciers. Others occupy long cracks in Earth's crust or form in volcanic craters. Many were once stretches of river that have been cut off from the main flow, while some were once parts of the sea.

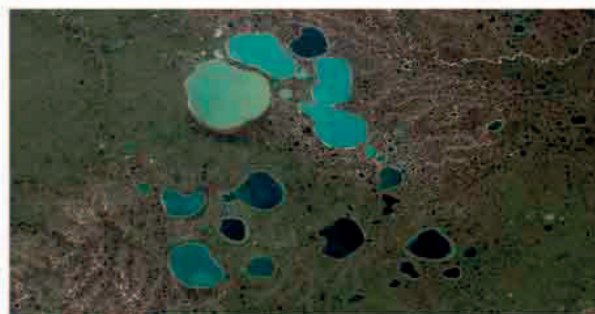
▼ GLACIAL LAKE

This lake, high in the Carpathian Mountains in Bulgaria, has formed in a hollow made by a glacier.



EBB AND FLOW

Some lakes are like hollows in a wet sponge, filling with water from below. As the level of the underground water table rises and falls, so does the level of the lake. Some fill rapidly, then empty almost overnight. These lakes are most common in limestone landscapes such as western Ireland, below.



KETTLE LAKES

Regions that were deep-frozen during a past ice age are often dotted with lakes. The ones in this satellite image of land near the Gulf of Ob in northern Russia are kettle lakes, formed as blocks of ice sank into soft ground and then melted.